The desk

Above: ARCHITECTURE.md §4.2 (the desk), §1 (how the desk learns) and §6 (a trading day).

Talks to:

- the front door, which brings it every page and API call;
- the files on the box: it is the only writer of each tool's file;
- the data sources and the shared record;
- the research worker, qp and the journal, whose timed work it starts;
- the backups and the alerts.

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1. What it is

One Node program that runs every tool. For each running tool it does what a tool's own program does today:

- serves its pages and its API;
- runs its screeners on schedule;
- builds and refreshes its cards;
- keeps its live list and its shortlist;
- takes its photo and measures its outcomes;
- scores its cards.

For each stopped tool it serves the history, read-only. It is also the desk's only scheduler.

What it owns:

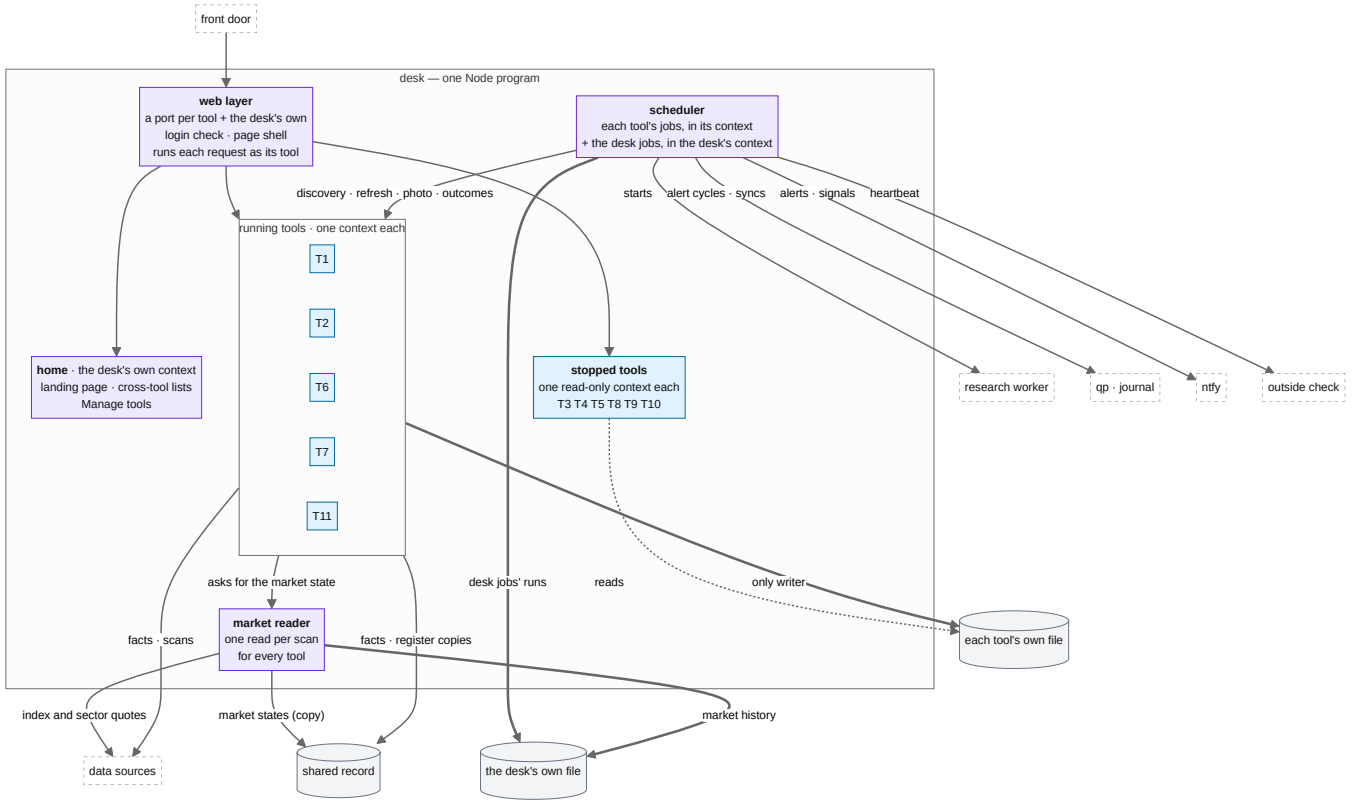
- each tool's own file, of which it is the only writer;
- its own file, for the desk jobs' runs and alerts, the market history and the desk's settings;
- the live state of every tool, in memory and saved to each tool's file after every change.

What it never does:

- **compute O'Neil data:** the research worker does;
- **evaluate a trading strategy:** qp does;
- **place an order;**
- **let one tool see another's results.**

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2. The diagram



3. The tool context: how one program holds many tools

The desk keeps tools apart with **contexts**. A context is everything that used to be one tool's program-wide state:

A context holds	Today, in a tool's own program, this was
the tool's identity: id, name, port, capture times, scorer	the environment the program was started with (`TOOL_ID`, `PORT`, …)
its file: the open database handle	the one database opened at start-up
its live list (R0)	a map in the program's memory
its scan status, market snapshot, hot sectors, scorer state	module variables
its jobs	the program's own scheduler
its role: running, stopped (read-only), or a comparison copy	—

How code finds its tool.

- Every piece of work runs inside one context: a page request, a job, a scan.
- Every request runs as its tool, and every job as the tool that registered it.
- Code asks "which tool am I working for?" and gets the context's answer, across every `await` and every timer.

Why two tools cannot mix. A database query made outside every context is an error in the desk, not a quiet write into T1's file. So a tool's results can only ever reach its own file.

The desk's own context. Home and the desk jobs run as the desk itself, with its own file. That is why every tool, T1 included, can be stopped.

The comparison copy. A context can also be a **copy** of a tool that still runs as its own program. A copy:

- follows the tool's screeners, settings and stars, read-only from the tool's file;
- writes only its own file;
- sends no alert and writes nothing shared;
- is compared with the tool's own photo every day.

This is how each tool proves it takes the same photo in the desk before it moves (MIGRATION.md step B).

Built: `src/toolContext.js` (migration step 15a). The copy and its daily comparison: `src/worker/` (step 15b).

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4. Its parts

Part	Job	Detail
web layer	brings every page and API call to its tool: one listener per tool port (so today's addresses keep working) and the desk's own; the login check; the page shell; live updates to open pages	WEB.md
home	the landing page; the lists across all tools (the unified shortlist, the screener report, the comparison); Manage tools (add, start, stop, pause, edit, delete, restore)	HOME.md
running tools	one tool end to end: its screeners and discovery, the card, the live list, the shortlist, the photo, the outcomes, the score, its pages and API	TOOL.md
stopped tools	a stopped tool's stored registers and history, read-only, on its own address	STOPPED-TOOLS.md
market reader	the indexes, the regime, the short-, mid- and long-term reads, the 15 sectors and hot sectors: read once per scan for every tool, stamped on every card, kept with its history in the desk's own file (R2 is that history at fixed minutes)	MARKET.md
scheduler and desk jobs	the only scheduler: every tool's jobs in its context, and the desk jobs (research runs, the night, the restore test, schedule changes, journal sync, qp's alert cycles with their signals pushed to the phone, the health checks, the heartbeat); every run recorded; failed, missed and hung runs alerted (ALERTS.md)	JOBS.md

4.1 Start-up

When the desk starts, it does the following in order. Every step is per tool, and none of them waits on the network.

1. **Read the tool registry.**
    - For each **running tool**:
        1. open its file;
        2. bring its schema up to date;
        3. seed its screeners if it has none (only for the built-in tools);
        4. bring back today's live list from the file;
        5. register its jobs.
    - For each **stopped tool**: open its file **read-only**.

    - **During the move** (MIGRATION.md steps A and B), the running tools are those listed in `deskTools`, and each tool listed in `workerShadow` opens as a copy.
2. **Open the desk's own context.** Register the desk jobs.
3. **Record missed jobs.** A job whose slot passed while the desk was down is recorded as missed and alerts. A photo is never taken late as if on time.
4. **Scan at once, if the session is open.** If it is between 04:00 and the close on a trading day, each running tool scans now, so a restart does not leave a list empty until the next scheduled scan.
5. **Listen on every tool's port** and the desk's own.

4.2 Containment: one tool cannot take another down

- **Every job of every tool runs wrapped:**
    - an error is recorded in that tool's run history, with its stack;
    - it alerts if the job is one that alerts;
    - it never ends the program.
- **Errors outside every job** are logged with their stack, and the program goes on.
- **Heavy work stays out of page requests.** Exports and long checks run as jobs or in pieces, so one page cannot hold up every tool's scans.
- **Bad configuration is refused on save** (HOME.md, SCREENERS.md), so a broken screener cannot reach the scans.

4.3 Memory

Budget. One copy of the code serves every tool: about 150–250 MB for the desk with five running tools (an estimate, to be measured as tools move in). Today the same work takes five programs at about 90 MB each, plus the archive.

What each tool costs is its live list and its caches: a few megabytes.

What is shared in memory across tools:

- the facts that do not depend on a tool (short interest, borrow, the O'Neil readings), cached once;
- the market read, made once per scan.

4.4 What changes for each tool's code

Almost nothing: the screener, card, register and page code is the code that runs today. What changed is where each tool's state is kept (§3), so the same code runs once per tool, in that tool's context.

4.5 The research each tool runs

Every running tool runs the same method, kept exactly as the old desk learned it:

- **The record of the day** (the photo, R1). At the tool's own minute in the first hour (today between 09:36 and 10:16), every card on its list is frozen exactly as it is known then. Only these records judge the tool.
- **Two entry minutes,** A and B, a few minutes after the record.
- **The outcome** (R3). After the close, the desk measures how far each recorded stock moved, up and down, from each entry minute to the close, in units of the stock's average daily range (ATR). A move of 1.3 ATR or more is a good move. There is no stop, target or exit in this measure: it judges what a tool finds, not a trade.

- **A benchmark tool** that every other tool must beat by a clear margin, and a **mirror** for each screener (the same setup facing the other way), to test whether its direction is real.
- **The order of work:** collect for about a month; cut the screeners whose stocks do not move; only then work on entries, stops and targets.

The exact measures: TOOL.md, and below it REGISTERS.md and LEARNING.md.

4.6 A trading day, by the clock

New York time, on trading days. Each job and its settings: JOBS.md.

When	Job	Who
03:45	every outside source checked	desk jobs
04:00–09:00 every 30 min; 09:00–10:00 every 5; 10:00–16:00 every 15; 16:00	discovery: each screener only inside its own window	each running tool, with one market read
04:00–16:00 every 5 min	every card re-quoted and re-scored	each running tool
04:00–16:00 every 5 min, while any wait	research for the stocks carded for the first time	desk jobs → research worker
09:00–15:30 every 30 min	the market model, provisional	desk jobs → research worker
09:25–16:05 every minute, while alerts are on	qp's alert cycle	desk jobs → qp
one minute before each tool's record	the shortlist rule	each running tool
each tool's minute (09:36 … 10:16 today)	**the record of the day** (R1)	each running tool
09:26, 09:31 … 10:01	R2: the market at fixed minutes, a view of the market history	the market reader
16:05	**the outcomes** (R3)	each running tool
16:50	capture-time changes made during the session take effect	desk jobs
18:30	the night: the O'Neil research, then the backup	desk jobs → research worker, backup
every minute, each account on its own interval	the journal's sync	desk jobs → journal
every 5 min	the heartbeat; the box's memory and disk	desk jobs
the 1st of each month, 09:10	the restore rehearsal	desk jobs
00:00	each tool's list starts a new day	each running tool

5. Contracts

It owns	Form
each tool's own file	SQLite, one per tool; the only writer (FILES.md)
the desk's own file	SQLite: the desk jobs, their runs, the desk's alert state; the market history; the desk's settings (FILES.md §3.2)
the live state of every tool	memory, saved to each tool's file after every change
the routes of every tool and of home	PAGES.md, HOME.md, WEB.md

It reads	From
the tool registry	`tools.config.json` and `data/tools.local.json` (FILES.md)
facts, O'Neil facts, market states	the shared record (SHARED-RECORD.md)
candidates, quotes, news, short interest, borrow, bars	the data sources, through their adapters (SOURCES.md)
the secrets	the secret files (BOX.md §4.3)

It starts	When
the research worker	the research jobs (JOBS.md)
qp's alert cycle	every minute in the session while alerts are on
the journal's sync	on each account's schedule
the backup	after the night's research run

6. When it fails

Event	What happens
the desk crashes	pm2 restarts it in seconds. Each tool's list comes back from its file; every run is in its file. A slot that passed while it was down is recorded as missed and alerts; a missed photo is never taken late
a tool's job throws	recorded in that tool's run history with its stack; alerts if it is a job that alerts; the other tools are unaffected
it passes its memory limit	pm2 restarts it, as a crash
the shared record is down	each tool works from its own file and fetches its facts itself; the copies wait; the health page says so
a data source fails	that source's facts show `unavailable` with the reason; the cards still build (SOURCES.md)
the front door is down	the desk keeps scanning and photographing; only the pages are out of reach
a scan outlasts its slot	the next slot is skipped and recorded; two scans of one tool never run at once
TradingView changes or drops a column	its adapter refuses the answer, and the scan report says why; no card gets shifted values (SOURCES.md)

7. Built on

The old desk. Every tool was its own program: five running tools at about 90 MB each, plus the archive serving the six stopped tools. Each program had:

- its own scheduler;
- its own copy of the pipeline;
- its own market read;
- its own caches.

The detail:

- today's architecture;

- TOOL-LIFECYCLE;
- MONITOR.

Why one program, not two

What the earlier design wanted, and why. It split the desk into two programs, desk-web for the pages and desk-worker for the jobs, for three reasons:

1. **Memory:** six programs on a 1 GB box.
2. **Speed and safety:** a slow scan must never freeze the pages, and the scheduler must never run twice.
3. **Tools as rows:** adding or stopping a tool should not mean a program, and a restart should lose nothing.

What building it showed.

- **The split was the hardest part.** Two programs share no memory. Everything a page shows from the scans (the live lists, the scan status, the market read, the jobs) would have had to be copied into the database all day, and every button (scan now, a star, a bias, a job switched off) would have become a message to the other program. That copying was the largest and riskiest part of the plan.
- **It broke one writer per file.** Both programs would have written each tool's file.
- **The speed reason hardly applies here.** A scan mostly waits on the network, not on the processor; each tool already serves its pages while it scans.
- **Two programs save less memory than one.** The saving comes from loading the code once; two programs load it twice.

What one program does instead. It keeps every one of those reasons: one copy of the code for every tool; one scheduler, which can never run twice; a tool as a context, not a process; and each tool's list saved to its file after every change, so a restart loses nothing. It also drops the copying, and keeps one writer per file.

Its risks. A crash stops every tool for a few seconds: the supervisor restarts the desk, and every list comes back from its file; a record whose minute passed is marked missed, and the phone is told. A heavy page could slow a scan: heavy work is kept out of page requests (§4.2). If that ever shows, the same code can still be split into two programs later, because the contexts make it possible.

Decided by the trader on 2026-10-08 (ARCHITECTURE §10).

What failed there

- **Memory.** Tools were stopped for lack of memory: each was a whole copy of the program.
- **The live list was lost on restart.** It lived only in memory, until a checkpoint and a scan at start-up were added.
- **T1 could not be stopped.** It carried the landing page, Manage tools and every desk-wide job.
- **A capture-time change needed a restart.** It waited until 16:50, because a restart in the session emptied the list.
- **The archive.** It served stopped tools by loading a separate copy of the modules for each one ("require-cache surgery").
- **The market was read five times a scan.** Five tools read the same ETFs minutes apart, and the hot sectors were forgotten on every restart.

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8. Status

Part	Status
the tool context	**built** (step 15a): one program can hold several tools, each kept apart; tested with two tools in one program
the comparison copy and its daily photo check	**built** (step 15b), in a separate program (`desk-worker`) that starts when a tool is listed in `workerShadow`. As a context of the desk: **to build** (migration step B)
stopped tools served by the desk	**to build** (migration step A): the desk's first job, in place of the archive
the desk running tools for real: pages, API and scans	**to build** (step B): tool by tool, after a clean week of photos
home and the desk jobs in the desk's own context	**to build** (step B, with T1, last)
the market reader	**in shadow** (step 6): one read stored per scan; each tool still reads its own (MARKET.md)
the scheduler	**partly**: run history and alerts built; one scheduler per tool until step B (JOBS.md)